

Sex Before Marriage

What YHWH Calls It, What It Joins, and the Way Back

A Teaching Study on 1 Corinthians 6:13-20

Scripture quoted from the World English Bible (WEB), divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai, with Yahshua and Messiah in place of Jesus and Christ. Torah is referred to throughout as the instructions of YHWH.

THE HEART OF IT

Our culture treats sex before marriage as normal, and many believers have quietly accepted the claim that the Bible never actually forbids it. The words YHWH chose say otherwise. The Greek, the Hebrew, and His own instructions all point the same direction.

Sex was designed to seal a covenant, not to test one. Outside of covenant it still joins two people, and that is exactly why it does so much damage. But this study does not end in condemnation. It ends in freedom.

HOW THIS STUDY WORKS

Each section sets out what the text says, the Hebrew or Greek words behind it, and what it means for how we walk. Where a common teaching phrase is not found in Scripture, the study says so plainly and shows what the text does say. Each section closes with questions for reflection or discussion.

SECTION I

The Text

Foods for the belly, and the belly for foods, but Elohim will bring to nothing both it and them. But the body is not for sexual immorality, but for Adonai; and Adonai for the body. Now Elohim raised up Adonai, and will also raise us up by his power. Don't you know that your bodies are members of Messiah? Shall I then take the members of Messiah and make them members of a prostitute? May it never be! Or don't you know that he who is joined to a prostitute is one body? For, The two, he says, will become one flesh. But he who is joined to Adonai is one spirit. Flee sexual immorality! Every sin that a man does is outside the body, but he who commits sexual immorality sins against his own body. Or don't you know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have from Elohim? You are not your own, for you were bought with a price. Therefore glorify Elohim in your body and in your spirit, which are Elohim's.

1 CORINTHIANS 6:13-20

Paul wrote this to believers in Corinth, a port city known across the Roman world for its sexual looseness. Some of them had decided that what they did with their bodies did not touch their spirits. Paul answers that the body belongs to Adonai, that sex joins two people whether they intend it or not, and that the price already paid for them settles

who owns their bodies.

SECTION II

The Bible Never Says It?

The most common objection is that Scripture condemns adultery, but never says a word about two single people who love each other. The answer starts with the word the Apostles actually used.

The Word Behind It

The Greek word is *porneia* (G4202), usually translated "fornication" or "sexual immorality." It comes from *pornē* (G4204), a harlot, and the lexicons trace that back to *pernēmi*, "to sell." At its root, *porneia* is intimacy pulled out of covenant and treated as a transaction.

Adultery has its own Greek word, *moicheia* (G3430). When Yahshua listed what comes out of a defiled heart, He named the two separately:

For out of the heart come evil thoughts, murders, adulteries, sexual sins, thefts, false testimony, and blasphemies.

MATTHEW 15:19

If *porneia* only meant cheating on a spouse, Yahshua would not have needed two words in the same breath. The writer of Hebrews does the same thing:

Let marriage be held in honor among all, and let the bed be undefiled; but Elohim will judge the sexually immoral and adulterers.

HEBREWS 13:4

Two groups again: the *pornos* (G4205), the sexually immoral, and the *moichos* (G3432), the adulterer. The first group is broader than the second, and it includes sex before marriage.

KEY POINT

Porneia is the umbrella. Adultery is one kind of sexual sin; sex outside of marriage in any form, including before it, falls under *porneia*. **Scripture names it, and Elohim says He will judge it.**

Paul says the same thing as a direct instruction:

For this is the will of Elohim: your sanctification, that you abstain from sexual immorality, that each one of you know how to control his own body in sanctification and honor, not in the passion of lust, even as the Gentiles who don't know Elohim,

1 THESSALONIANS 4:3-5

The word for sanctification is *hagiasmos* (G38), being set apart. Sexual purity is not a side issue for a believer. Paul calls it the will of Elohim.

For Reflection

- Where did you first hear that the Bible does not forbid sex before marriage?
- Why do you think Yahshua and the writer of Hebrews kept the two words separate?

SECTION III

What the Hebrew Calls It

The instructions of YHWH use the Hebrew word *zanah* (H2181), to commit harlotry or fornication. The clearest case of how He applies it to an unmarried woman is in Deuteronomy 22.

In Deuteronomy 22:13-21, a husband accuses his new bride of not having been a virgin. If the charge is false, he is fined and may never divorce her. If it is true, the text says:

then they shall bring out the young lady to the door of her father's house, and the men of her city shall stone her to death with stones, because she has done folly in Israel, to play the prostitute in her father's house. So you shall remove the evil from among you.

DEUTERONOMY 22:21

"Play the prostitute" is *zanah*. This woman was not married when it happened. She was not cheating on anyone. And the instructions still call it harlotry and folly in Israel. That settles how YHWH defines sex before marriage.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN

The death penalty in this passage was carried out by Israel's courts, in the land, on the testimony of witnesses. This study is not teaching that anyone should be stoned today. It is showing how YHWH defines the act. The penalty tells you how seriously He takes it; the rest of Scripture tells you where mercy is found.

For Reflection

- Does it surprise you that Deuteronomy uses the word for harlotry about an unmarried woman?
- Why would YHWH treat something done "in her father's house" as a matter for the whole community?

SECTION IV

You Open It, You Bought It

Everyone knows how it works at the grocery store. You can pick something up and read the label. But once you tear the package open and start eating, you are not a shopper anymore. You are paying for it. YHWH wrote that principle into His instructions, and He wrote it to protect the woman.

If a man entices a virgin who isn't pledged to be married, and lies with her, he shall surely pay a dowry for her to be his wife. If her father utterly refuses to give her to him, he shall pay money according to the dowry of virgins.

EXODUS 22:16-17

The Words Behind It

"Virgin" is *bethulah* (H1330). "Entices" is *pathah* (H6601), to persuade, to sweet talk, even to deceive. This is the man who says the covenant is only a piece of paper. "Dowry" is *mohar* (H4119), the bride-price.

Notice what the instruction does. The man pays the full bride-price whether or not he gets to marry her. Her father could refuse the marriage altogether, and the man still paid. **The cost landed on him, not on her.**

Deuteronomy adds a second case:

If a man finds a lady who is a virgin, who is not pledged to be married, grabs her and lies with her, and they are found, then the man who lay with her shall give to the lady's father fifty shekels of silver. She shall be his wife, because he has humbled her. He may not put her away all his days.

DEUTERONOMY 22:28-29

"Grabs" is *taphas* (H8610), to seize or take hold of. "Humbled" is *anah* (H6031), to afflict, to bring low, to violate. YHWH saw what the act did to her, and He made sure the man could never use her and walk away. No divorce, all his days.

KEY POINT

The analogy works because of who it protects. The woman is not the product in this picture. **The instruction made sure no man could open what he was not willing to pay for, and could never walk away from what he took.**

For Reflection

- What does it say about YHWH that the cost of this sin fell on the one who pursued it?
- How does the phrase "it is just a piece of paper" sound after reading the word *pathah*?

SECTION V

Bought at the Marketplace

Or don't you know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have from Elohim? You are not your own, for you were bought with a price. Therefore glorify Elohim in your body and in your spirit, which are Elohim's.

1 CORINTHIANS 6:19-20

The Greek word for "bought" is *agorazō* (G59), from *agora* (G58), the marketplace. It is the everyday word for buying something in the market square. Paul takes the grocery store picture and turns it around. You are not the shopper in this story. You have already been purchased, and the price was the blood of Yahshua.

"Temple" is *naos* (G3485), not the general word for the temple grounds but the word for the inner sanctuary, the dwelling place itself. Your body is where the Spirit of Elohim lives. That is why Paul can say the body is not for sexual immorality, but for Adonai, and Adonai for the body (1 Corinthians 6:13).

Your body is not yours to hand out. It belongs to the One who paid for it.

For Reflection

- How does knowing you were bought change the question "what is wrong with it if we love each other?"
- What would it look like this week to glorify Elohim in your body?

SECTION VI

One Flesh

Therefore a man will leave his father and his mother, and will join with his wife, and they will be one flesh.

GENESIS 2:24

"Join" is *dabaq* (H1692), to cling, to stick fast, to be glued together. That is YHWH's design: two lives fused into one, inside of covenant.

Now watch the same word appear where there was no covenant at all. Shechem took Dinah, lay with her, and humbled her, and right after, Scripture says:

His soul joined to Dinah, the daughter of Jacob, and he loved the young lady, and spoke kindly to the young lady.

GENESIS 34:3

"Soul" is *nephesh* (H5315), and "joined" is *dabaq* again. The act created a bond in him, with no covenant, no consent from her, and no blessing from her father. The bond did not make it right. It made the damage worse, and the chapter ends with bloodshed (Genesis 34:25).

Paul says the same thing in the Greek:

Or don't you know that he who is joined to a prostitute is one body? For, The two, he says, will become one flesh. But he who is joined to Adonai is one spirit.

1 CORINTHIANS 6:16-17

"Joined" is *kollaō* (G2853), to glue or cement together. Paul quotes Genesis 2:24 about a man and a prostitute. Sex outside of marriage does not escape the one flesh reality. It sets that reality in motion with someone you have no covenant with. And notice verse 17: the same verb describes being joined to Adonai. He designed us to be joined, to Him first and to one spouse in covenant.

WHERE SCRIPTURE STOPS

The phrase "soul tie" is not found in Scripture. It is a teaching term. What Scripture does show is the reality behind it: *dabaq* in Genesis 34:3, a soul clinging after the act, and *kollaō* in 1 Corinthians 6:16, two people glued into one body. Teach the verses, and let the term stay a term.

For Reflection

- Why do you think people often feel bound to someone they know was not good for them?
- What does verse 17 tell you about what you were actually made to be joined to?

SECTION VII

A Sin Against Your Own Body

Flee sexual immorality! Every sin that a man does is outside the body, but he who commits sexual immorality sins against his own body.

1 CORINTHIANS 6:18

"Flee" is *pheugō* (G5343), to run for your life. It is the word used when Joseph was told to flee into Egypt with the child (Matthew 2:13). Paul does not tell them to manage it, negotiate with it, or see how close they can get. He tells them to run. Joseph is the picture: when Potiphar's wife grabbed his garment, he left it in her hand and ran out of the house (Genesis 39:12).

Paul says this sin is different because it is committed against your own body, the very place the Spirit dwells. It is not only something you do. It is something done to the temple.

What About Open Doors?

Scripture does not use the phrase "open door" for this, but it does give a principle:

and don't give place to the devil.

EPHESIANS 4:27

"Place" is *topos* (G5117), a spot, a piece of ground. In context Paul is talking about anger, not sex, so this is a principle and not a proof text. But it runs through all of Scripture: sin that is practiced and not confessed hands the enemy ground to stand on. In deliverance ministry, bonds from past relationships are often the ground that has to be taken back before a marriage can be whole.

KEY POINT

Every other sin a man commits is outside the body. **This one is committed in the temple itself.** That is why the instruction is not "be careful." It is "run."

For Reflection

- What situations do you need to run from instead of trying to stand in?
- Is there ground in your life that you have handed over and never taken back?

SECTION VIII

Already Crossed the Line?

Most people reading this have a past. YHWH did not give the truth to crush anyone. He gave it so we could be free. Look at what Paul says right after he lists the sexually immoral among those who will not inherit the Kingdom:

Some of you were such, but you were washed. But you were sanctified. But you were justified in the name of Adonai Yahshua, and in the Spirit of our Elohim.

1 CORINTHIANS 6:11

"Some of you were such." That is past tense. The people in Corinth had lived in *porneia*, and Yahshua washed them. What He did for them, He will do for you. Here is what walking out of it looks like.

1. Call It What YHWH Calls It

Not a mistake, not "we were in love," but sin. Confession means agreeing with Elohim about what it was.

If we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous to forgive us the sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.

1 JOHN 1:9

2. Bring It Into the Light

Shame lives in secret. It loses its power in the light.

Confess your offenses to one another, and pray for one another, that you may be healed.

JAMES 5:16

3. Renounce the Bond

Speak it out loud in the name of Yahshua: you are no longer joined to that person, and you take back every piece of ground you handed the enemy. Scripture gives no ritual for this, and none is needed. It is confession, repentance, and a clear declaration of whose you are.

4. Forgive

Forgive the one who pressured or used you, and receive the forgiveness Yahshua already paid for. Unforgiveness keeps the chain attached. Forgiveness is the root of deliverance.

5. Walk as a New Creation

Therefore if anyone is in Messiah, he is a new creation. The old things have passed away. Behold, all things have become new.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:17

RIGHT WHERE YOU ARE

If you are single: you are not damaged goods. Guard what He restored. The Song of Songs says three times that love should not be stirred up or awakened until it so desires (Song of Songs 2:7, 3:5, 8:4).

If you are living together: Paul gives the answer plainly. It is better to marry than to burn (1 Corinthians 7:9). Make the covenant, or step back until you can.

If you are married and carrying bonds from before: pray through this together. YHWH restores marriages. That is His design, and it is what this ministry exists for.

For Reflection

- Which of the five steps is hardest for you, and why?
- Who is one trusted person you could bring this into the light with?

SECTION IX

Cross Reference Index

Primary text: 1 Corinthians 6:12-20

Porneia named apart from adultery: Matthew 15:19; Mark 7:21-22; Hebrews 13:4; Galatians 5:19

The will of Elohim: 1 Thessalonians 4:3-8; Romans 12:1

Zanah before marriage: Deuteronomy 22:13-21

The man pays: Exodus 22:16-17; Deuteronomy 22:28-29

Bought with a price: 1 Corinthians 6:19-20; 1 Corinthians 7:23; 1 Peter 1:18-19

One flesh: Genesis 2:24; Genesis 34:3; Matthew 19:5-6; 1 Corinthians 6:16-17; Ephesians 5:31

Flee: 1 Corinthians 6:18; Genesis 39:12; 2 Timothy 2:22

Giving ground: Ephesians 4:27; James 4:7

Washed and made new: 1 Corinthians 6:11; 1 John 1:9; James 5:16; 2 Corinthians 5:17

Wait for it: Song of Songs 2:7, 3:5, 8:4; 1 Corinthians 7:2, 7:9

PUTTING IT INTO PRAYER

Yahshua, You bought me with Your own blood, and my body belongs to You. I confess every place I gave myself outside of covenant, and I call it what You call it. Wash me. In Your name I renounce every bond I formed outside of Your design, and I take back every piece of ground I handed the enemy. I forgive those who used me, and I receive Your forgiveness. Make me new. Teach me to flee, to wait, and to honor You in my body. Amen.

Personal Notes and Convictions

Restoring YHWH's design for marriage, family, forgiveness, and deliverance.